



VALENCIA SPAIN

The Original Paella in Valencia

The pearl of eastern Iberia, Valencia was contested between Christians and Moors in medieval times, and the old town echoes with these ancient cultures. In stark contrast, the City of Arts and Sciences may be the world's most futuristic complex. Old or new, every quarter of the city cherishes paella, a dish that perfectly captures the salty, earthy essence of Valencia.



Valencia's medieval center, its exceptional white-sand beaches, and its gleaming modern yacht harbor should be enough to satisfy anyone. But after the Turia River flooded catastrophically in 1957,

Valencia remade itself by rerouting the river and creating a parkland in the dry riverbed. The capstone of civic reinvention was the astonishing City of Arts and Sciences, a "city within a city" designed by native son and avant-garde architectural superstar Santiago Calatrava. So marvelous is this paean to artistic and scientific discovery that visitors are torn between just wandering among the buildings, which function as giant-scale outdoor sculpture, and going inside to wander among first-class exhibitions and performances.

No such transformation has ever been necessary to Valencian cuisine, where paella is king. When the Moors introduced rice to Europe through Valencia in the 8th century, the dish became all but inevitable. The original *paella valenciana* uses the bounty of the garden plot to create a dish that is simultaneously light and earthy, as crisp green beans combine with sweet tomatoes and peppers and the chewy, meaty morsels of

land snails and hare. The more famous *paella de mariscos* bristles with the sweet, crunchy shrimp and other shellfish of the Valencian coast. But in every form of paella, the rice is key.

Valencian rice can absorb up to four times its volume in liquid while still remaining firm, swelling prodigiously as it soaks up wine, fish broth, chicken stock, squid ink, or vegetable juices. Cooked in a *paellera* – the shallow, wide iron pan that gives paella its name – the dish forms a definitive nutty, caramelized golden crust, or *socarrat*, at the base of the pan. The best paellas also absorb a smoky flavor from cooking over a wood fire.

Some of the city's leading paella restaurants are found on Playa Malvarossa, the broad beach where locals and visitors swim and bask in the Mediterranean sun. Diners patiently await tables, knowing that the rituals of paella cannot be rushed. First comes the difficult choice over the type of paella, then the wait, as the dish is prepared to order, before – finally – the waiter presents a *paellera* big enough to serve the entire table. It is a celebration of centuries of gastronomic fusion in a single dish.

The Mercado Central

More than 400 vendors fill Valencia's central food market, and many more spill out on to the adjoining sidewalks and streets. The 1928 Modernista building is often cited as one of the largest covered markets in Europe. With its soaring ceilings and ornate central dome, it is a modern cathedral of gastronomy. Yet the fanciful architecture is upstaged by the bounty and beauty of the food stalls – pyramids of sweet oranges, glistening clear-eyed fish splayed out on crushed ice, thick green pods of fresh fava beans. The rich choices perhaps explain why Valencia's cooks have invented so many variations of paella. Stall-hopping yields the essentials – large cloth bags of heirloom Bomba rice, heaping mounds of bright paprika, small tins of precious saffron, and an iron *paellera*.

A Day in Valencia

The ages of Valencia's long history are evident everywhere. The Cathedral alone incorporates Roman relics and a Moorish minaret as its bell tower. As the city radiates outward, it becomes ever more modern, culminating in the futuristic fantasies of the architecture at the City of Arts and Sciences.

MORNING Marvel at the restored Renaissance-era frescoes in the stately **Cathedral**, then climb the minaret-turned-bell tower for a panorama of the old city. Across **Plaza de la Reina** in an extravagant Baroque palace, the **Museo Nacional de Cerámica** features a charming tiled Valencian kitchen.

AFTERNOON After photographing the interplay of forms in the **City of Arts and Sciences**, visit the planetarium at **L'Hemisfèric** or catch the graceful play of beluga whales and bottlenose dolphins at **L'Oceanogràfic**.

EVENING Stroll the narrow streets of the old fishermen's quarter, **El Cabanyal**, until you reach the broad strand of **Playa Malvarossa**. Catch the last rays of the sun at this urban beach or join the Valencians as they promenade along the shore before an evening of socializing and dining.



Above The futuristic buildings of the City of Arts and Sciences include a science museum (pictured), opera house, planetarium, and the largest aquarium in Europe

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Many European and Spanish airlines fly into **Valencia Airport**, and the city is well-served by **train** services from points all over Spain.

WHERE TO STAY

Hostal Venecia (inexpensive) has modest but cheerful rooms in a landmark building downtown. www.hotelvenecia.com

Hotel Meliá Valencia (moderate) offers stylish, modern rooms near the City of Arts and Sciences. www.melia-hotels.com

Hotel Neptuno (expensive) makes the most of its beachfront location on Playa Malvarossa with a rooftop solarium. www.hotelneptunovalencia.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Calle Paz; www.comunitatvalenciana.com